



A special bond: Federer played his last professional tennis match with his greatest rival and best friend at the 2022 Laver Cup.

even five seemingly impossible defensive gets. After winning the clay-court match, I predicted, “Nadal will win four to eight French Opens,” even though the long-haired, determined Spaniard needed to improve significantly on other surfaces. Over the years, Toni and Carlos Moya, Nadal’s longtime friend and advisor from Mallorca — who replaced Toni as head coach in 2018 — honed Nadal’s technique and tactics. Nadal added power to his groundstrokes and improved his volley and serve. No longer a one-trick pony, he reached the

Wimbledon finals in 2006 and 2007, winning the coveted title in 2008.

Before the 2008 US Open, where Nadal had never advanced past the quarterfinals in five appearances, Toni said, “Rafael needs to play like he is on grass all the time. He is still young. He has learned how to play on grass and make three finals. He will learn this on hard courts.”

Following a similar progression, Nadal made the semifinals at Flushing Meadows in 2008 and 2009, and in 2010, he captured the only Major that had eluded him. His first serve, which averaged a modest 107 mph in 2009, shot up to an impressive 118 mph in 2010.

His volleying also improved dramatically. “His net play is way, way better than your average clay-court

player. You can make a solid argument that he’s a better volleyer than Federer,” said McEnroe for CBS during Nadal’s sensational 6-4, 5-7, 6-4, 6-2 victory over Djokovic in the 2010 US Open final.

Whether blasting astonishing forehand winners on the dead run from outside the alley or belting backhand passing shots, Nadal evolved into an offensive juggernaut and a baseline grinder. “To be in such defensive positions and hit outright winners is something I had never seen in this sport before Nadal arrived,” McEnroe raved.

When Nadal captured his second US Open title in 2013, all-time great Billie Jean King told *Inside Tennis*, “Nadal is the most adaptable player I’ve seen in years. Every year he is better on hard courts. Same thing with the first time I saw him play on grass and now. He is so adaptable, and that is very hard to find in people. He’s amazing.”

By age 32, after taking his record 11th title at the Barcelona Open, Nadal noted, “Now I look for more angles, trying to open the court” to set up forehand winners. This tactic also applied to his serve, where his odds of winning the point increased dramatically, particularly when serving wide in the ad court, when his second shot was hit with a forehand more than 80 per cent of the time.

What former No. 1 Jim Courier rated as “the best forehand I’ve ever seen” was produced with a Western grip and a pronounced low-to-high, lasso-like swing with several different follow-throughs. These diabolically spinning “heavy” balls averaged 3,300 RPM — significantly faster than the ATP top 50 average of 2,800 RPM. These fearsome forehands bounded higher and wider (on crosscourt forehands), forcing errors and eventually wearing out opponents.

In Nadal’s never-ending quest for perfection, court-positioning became his final frontier. A 2020 *New York Times* article referenced the findings of Sam Maclean, a data analyst with Hawkeye, which showed that in his 30s, Nadal’s long, gruelling rallies gave way to aggressive, first-strike tennis.